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Class 2: Causes, Radicalisation, Mobilisation

Causes: Setting the stage for political violence

Dr. Michael C. Zeller

Agenda for the day

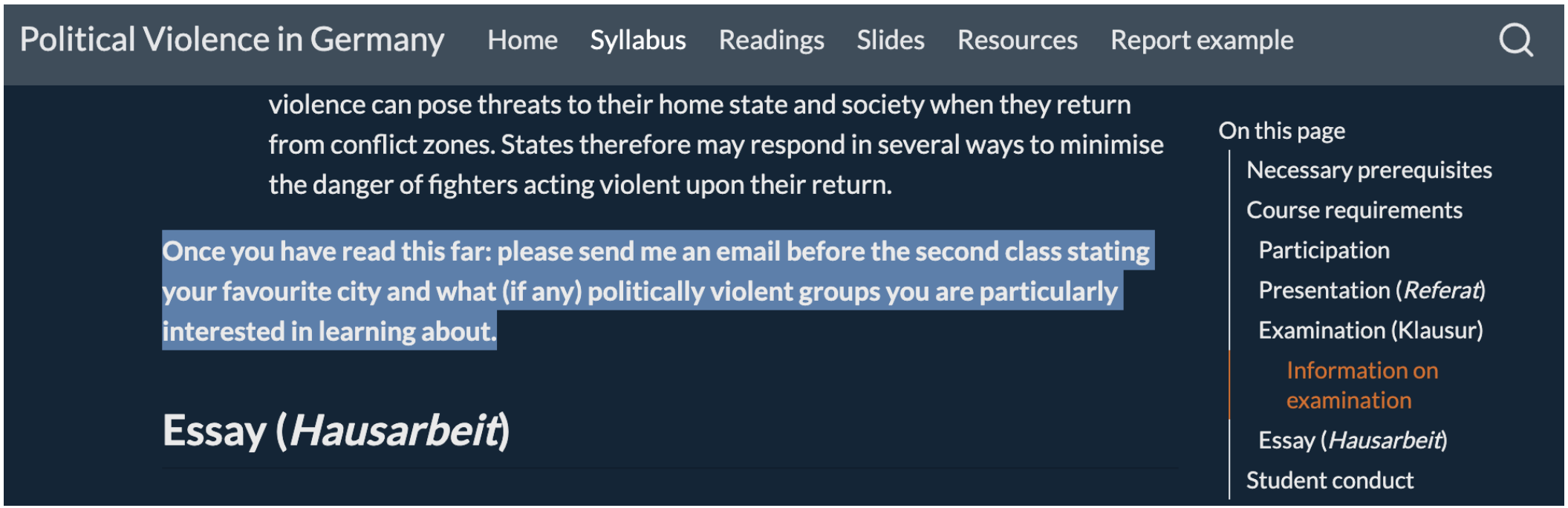
- Opening notes
- A causal framework of political violence
- Politically violent groups connected to Germany
- Open data - Global Terrorism Database
- Other PV groups that will crop up in readings
- Assigning groups for in-depth study
- Testing: determinants of right-wing terrorism in the U.S.
- Any feedback for this class?

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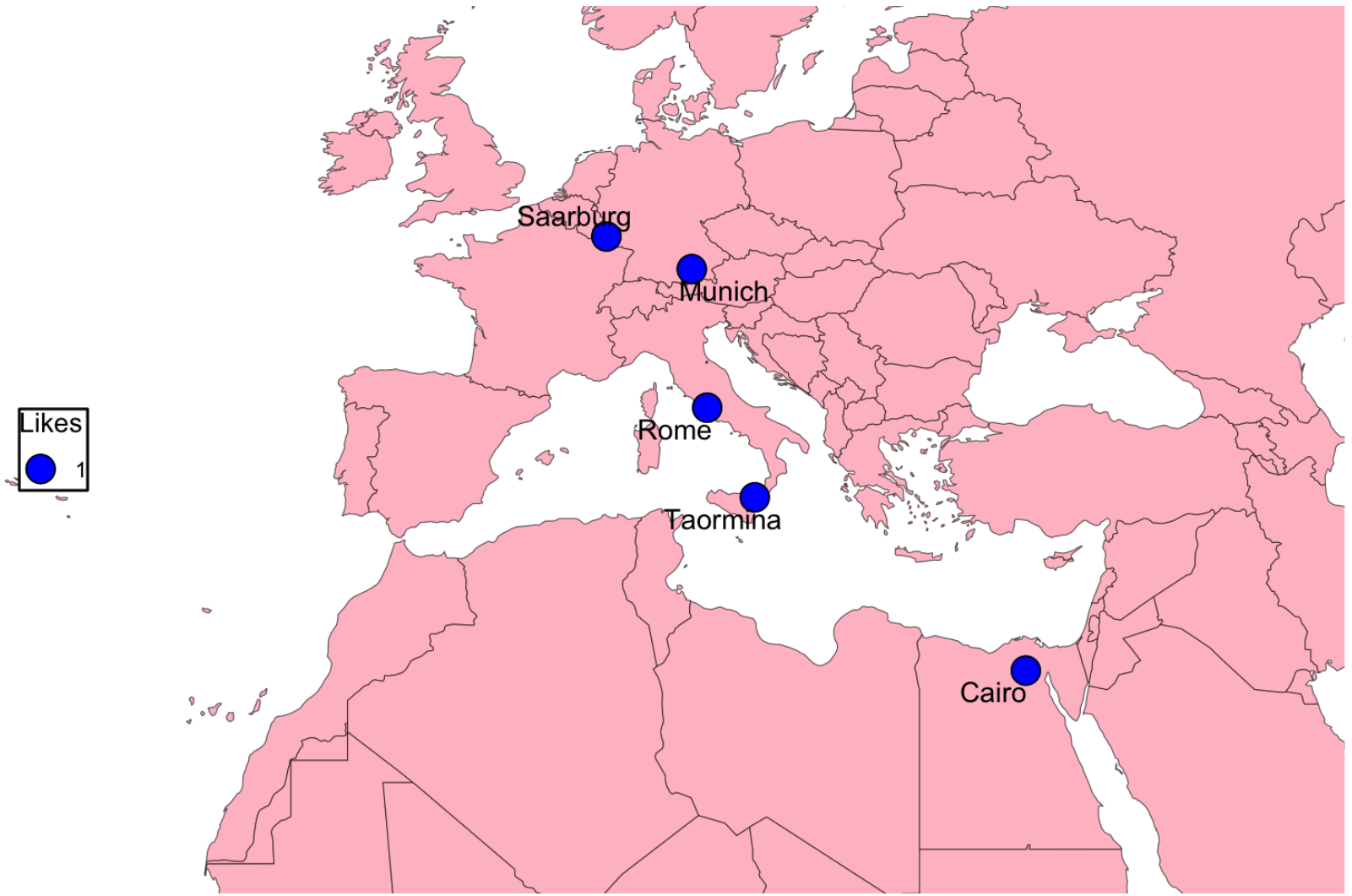
Opening notes



Syllabus reading check



Students' favourite cities



Presentation groups

Remember: topic to me at least by Week 4

December | January

Presentations line-up

Date	Presenters	Method
7 Dec:		TBD
14 Dec:		TBD
21 Dec:		TBD

A causal framework of political violence

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Three organising questions (Crenshaw 1981)

- Terrorist violence communicates a political message; its ends go beyond damaging an enemy's material resources

1. why does terrorism occur?
   - *predictive/causal* questions

2. how do the processes of terrorism work?
   - *processual/mechanistic* questions

3. what are its social and political effects?
   - *descriptive* and *causal* questions

Common problems (Crenshaw 1981)

(still applicable to significant portions of political violence and research several decades on…)

- logical comparability
- specification of the relationship of variables to each other
- rank-ordering of variables in terms of explanatory power

3 levels of causation (Crenshaw 1981)

1. broad environment/contextual factors (macro-level)
2. circumstances and actors (meso-level)
3. psychological variables that encourage or inhibit (micro-level)

- these *levels* are a useful and widely applicable analytical framework

Context (macro-level): preconditions

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Any ideas what is depicted here?



Context (macro-level): preconditions

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Context (macro-level): precipitants

- precipitants, specific events that immediately precede the occurrence of terrorism

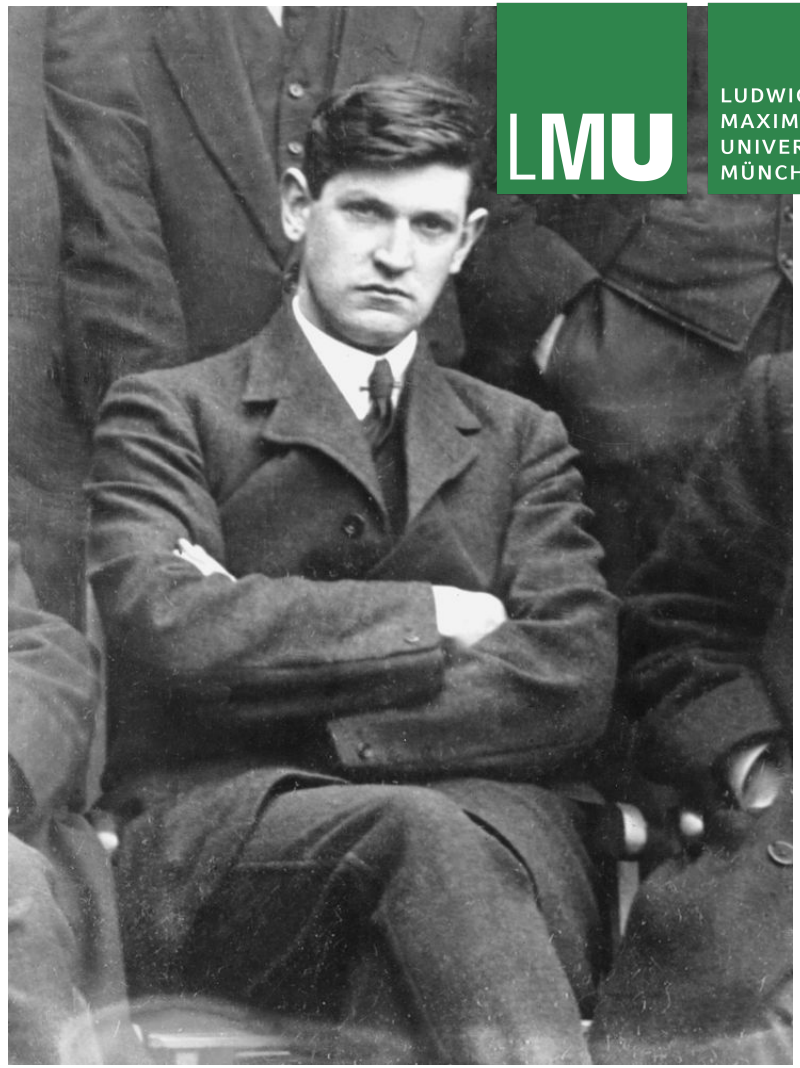
> a common pattern of government actions that act as catalysts for terrorism. Government use of unexpected and unusual force in response to protestor reform attempts often compels terrorist retaliation. (p384)

Examples?

Context (macro-level): precipitants

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IRISH REPUBLICAN ARMY
Leaders in the Insurrection, May, 1916
IRISH REBELLION, MAY 1916
THOMAS MacDONAGH
Executed May 3rd, 1916.
J. J. HEUSTON,
Executed May 8th, 1916.
CORNELIUS COLBERT
Executed May 8th, 1916.
SEAN MAC DIARMADA,
Executed May 9th, 1916.
THE O'RAHILLY.
One of the Leaders, who was Shot in Action, G.P.O. Area.
MAJOR JOHN McBRIDE
Executed in Kilmainham Prison, May 5th, 1916.
P. H. PEARSE
Executed May 3rd, 1916.
JAMES CONNOLLY
Executed May 9th, 1916.
THOMAS ASHE
Sentenced to Death;
E. DALY
Executed May 4th, 1916.
EAMONN CEANNT
Executed May 8th, 1916.
COUNTESS MARKIEVICZ
Sentenced to Death;
MICHAEL O'HANRAHAN
Executed in Kilmainham Prison, May 4th, 1916.
ED. de VALERA
Sentenced to Death;
THOMAS J. CLARKE,
Executed May 3rd, 1916.
JOSEPH PLUNKETT (son of Count Plunkett),
Executed May 4th, 1916.
Printed and Published by the Powell Press, 22 Parliament Street, Dublin.



Context (macro-level): precipitants

- precipitants, specific events that immediately precede the occurrence of terrorism

> a common pattern of government actions that act as catalysts for terrorism. Government use of unexpected and unusual force in response to protestor reform attempts often compels terrorist retaliation. (p384)

Examples?

Circumstances (meso-level) (Crenshaw 1981)

- terrorist behaviour as “rational”
  - based on assumption that terrorist organisations have consistent sets of values, beliefs, and images of the environment. Hence, terrorism is seen collectively as a logical means
- variety of goals
  - from revolutionary - e.g., new state, new system
  - to (essentially) conservative - e.g., preserve social group relations, power arrangements

Circumstances (meso-level): variety of goals (1981)

- can serve long-term strategy and/or proximate objectives
- gain attention, win support
- disrupt/discredit government/state
- provoke reactions:
  - affects public attitudes positively and negatively, creating either sympathy in a potential constituency or fear and hostility in an audience identified as the "enemy."
  - government counteraction
- internal organisation functions: control, discipline, morale-building
- actors' impatience

Circumstances (meso-level) (Crenshaw 1981)

> The observation that terrorism is a weapon of the weak is hackneyed but apt. (p387)

What does this mean? Do you agree?

- inexpensive, simple
- contrast: James C. Scott's book (1985), *Weapons of the Weak: Everyday Forms of Peasant Resistance*

Psychological (micro-level): common traits (Crensha

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two fundamental questions about the psychological basis of terrorism:

1. why the individual takes the first step and chooses to engage in terrorism: why join? Does the terrorist possess specific psychological predispositions, identifiable in advance, that suit them for terrorism?
   - radicalisation and engagement

2. Why does involvement continue? What are the psychological mechanisms of group interaction?
   - persistence or endurance

Psychological (micro-level): common traits (Crensha

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- ego-defensive needs
- cognitive processes
- socialisation

- in interaction with a specific situation
- different acts of terror can carry differences in psychological demands
  - extremely discriminate (e.g., assassination) to broadly indiscriminate (recall patterns of violence conceptual framework)

BUT: avoid stereotyping the terrorist or oversimplifying: No single motivation or personality can be valid for all circumstances

Psychological (micro-level): normality (Crenshaw 19

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> "the outstanding common characteristic of terrorists is their normality"

> The West German psychiatrist who conducted a pretrial examination of four members of the RAF concluded that they were "intelligent," even "humorous," and showed no symptoms of psychosis or neurosis and "no particular personality type." (p390)

Psychological (micro-level): difficulties (Crenshaw 1

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studying individuals engaged in terrorism presents problems:

- preconditions change over time and precipitants are unpredictable
- interviewing terrorists: may discover subsequent rationalisations instead of prior attitudes/motivations

Psychological (micro-level): endurance (Crenshaw 1

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Within terrorist groups, individual/group dynamics of …

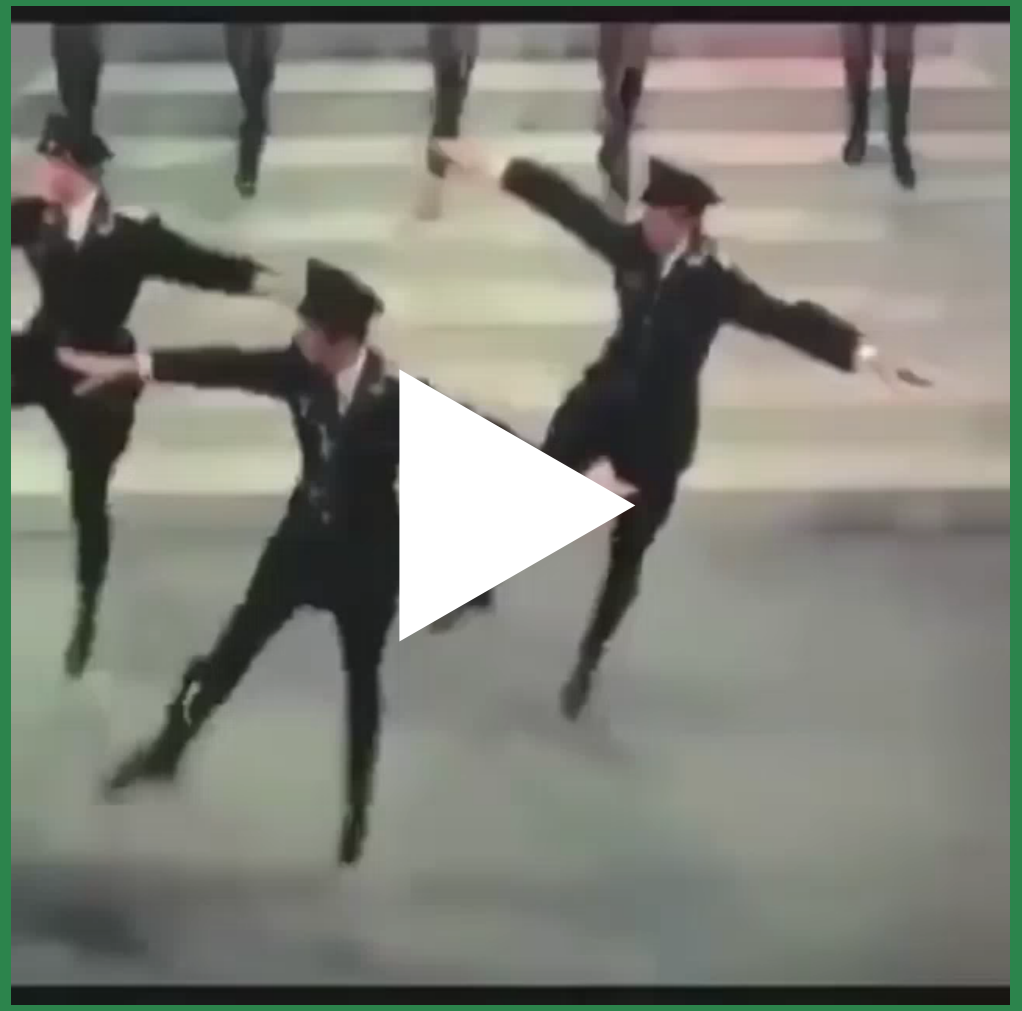
- commitment,
- risk,
- solidarity,
- loyalty,
- guilt,
- revenge,
- isolation

discourage a change in behaviour (and at the organisational level, strategy)—even when contextual conditions change.

Politically violent groups connecte[illegible] Germany

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- open to discussion on all sorts of non-state (potentially) politically violent groups
- highlighting roster of PV organisations to be assigned
- introduction of those (and other) cases



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(In)famous PV groups in or connected to Germany

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> "Those who only know one country, know no country" - Seymour Martin Lipset (inspired by Alexis de Tocqueville)

- well-known and covered in research literature
- diverse strategies, objectives, and ideological characteristics
- active in Germany and/or banned by Germany (or EU)

- we will also discuss other cases (e.g., IRA), including ones [illegible] of, just remember:
  - aim is to *analyse* and *understand*
  - most PV groups involve charged political issues, so remember:
    - treat each other with mutual respect
    - most are working in 2nd/3rd/4th language, so do not assume provocation if you disagree with an expression

(In)famous PV groups in or connected to Germany

al-Qaeda (alQaeda, transnational),
Antifaschistische Aktion (Antifa, Germany and elsewhere),
Islamic State (IS, transnational),
Nationaldemokratische Partei Deutschlands ('National Democratic Party of Germany,' NPD, Germany),
National Socialist Underground (NSU, Germany),
Partiya Karkerên Kurdistanê ('Kurdistan Workers' Party,' PKK, Turkey, Syria and several other countries including Germany),
Rote Armee Fraktion ('Red Army Fraction,' RAF, Germany),

al-Qaeda

- Territory of action: international
- Organisational structure: (hierarchical) network
- Membership: large
- (main) Objective: global Islamic caliphate
- (common) Targets: U.S. and Western institutions and societies
- Repertoire of actions: terrorism



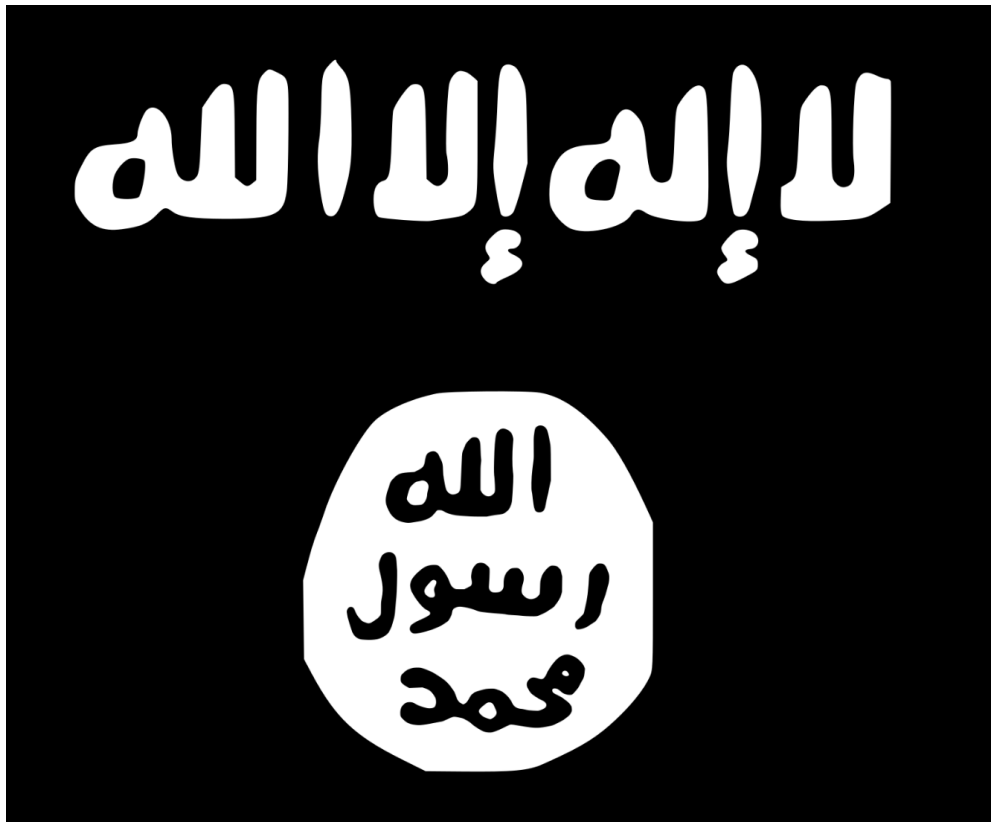
Antifa

- Territory of action: international
- Organisational structure: network
- Membership: large
- (main) Objective: oppose fascist forces
- (common) Targets: political opponents
- Repertoire of actions: low-level violence, property damage, doxxing



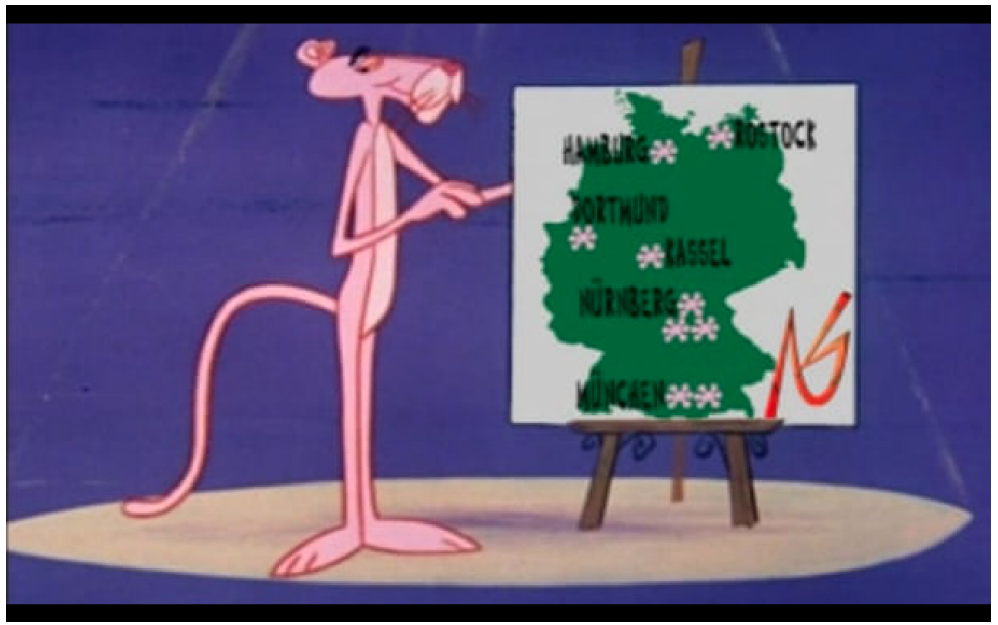
Islamic State

- Territory of action: international
- Organisational structure: network
- Membership: large
- (main) Objective: Islamic caliphate
- (common) Targets: political, ethnic, religious opponents
- Repertoire of actions: terrorism, militarised combat



National Socialist Underground

- Territory of action: Germany
- Organisational structure: network
- Membership: small
- (main) Objective: terrorise non-ethnic Germans
- (common) Targets: non-ethnic Germans
- Repertoire of actions: murder, robbery



Nationaldemokratische Partei Deutschlands (NPD)

- Territory of action: Germany
- Organisational structure: hierarchical
- Membership: large
- (main) Objective: German ethno-state
- (common) Targets: political and ethnic opponents
- Repertoire of actions: low-level violence, support for terrorism

Partiya Karkeren Kurdistane

- Territory of action: prominently Turkey, but international advocates
- Organisational structure:
- Membership: large
- (main) Objective: Kurdish statehood
- (common) Targets: Turkish military and state
- Repertoire of actions: guerrilla activity



Rote Armee Fraktion

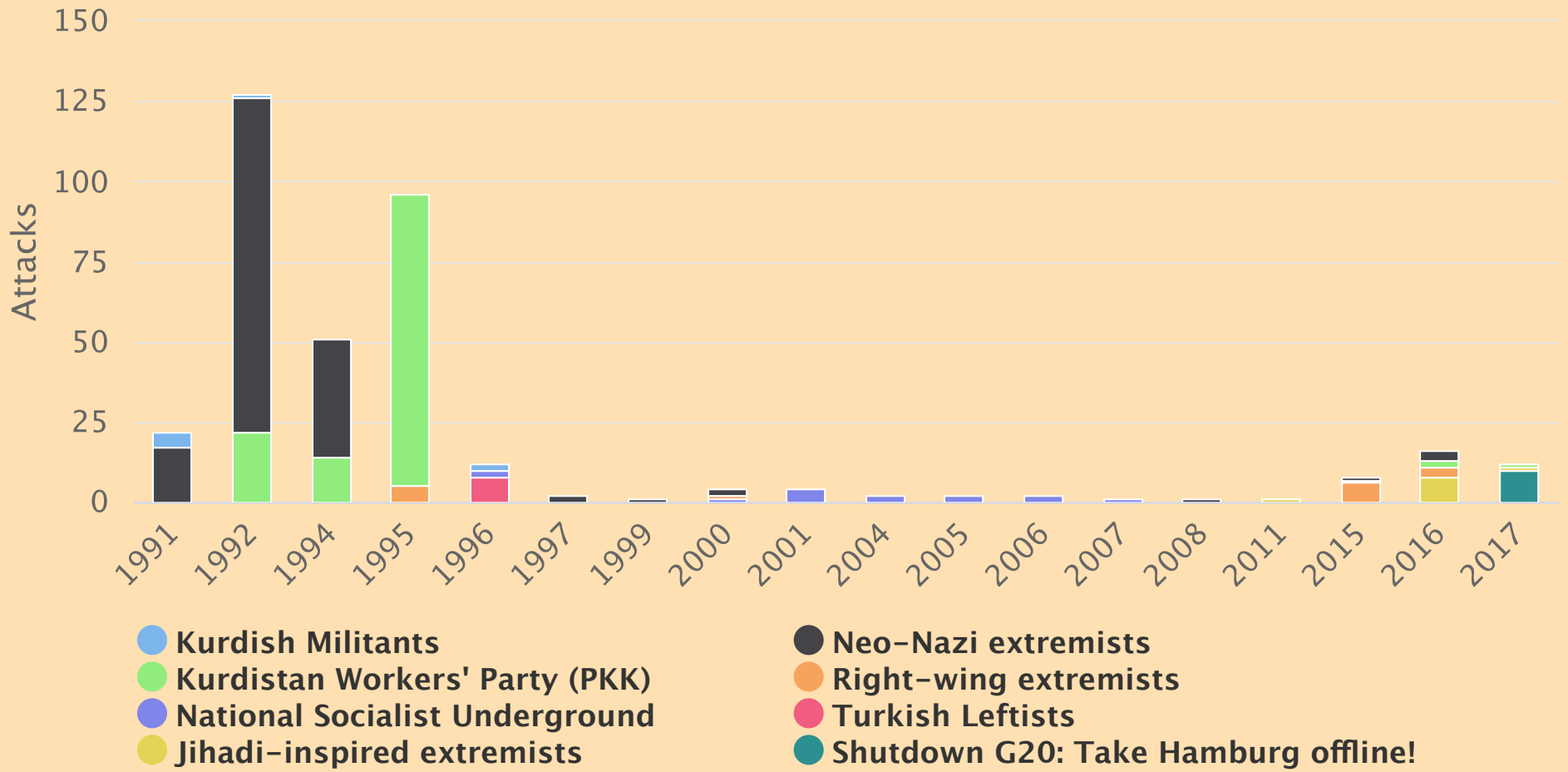
- Territory of action: Germany
- Organisational structure: network
- Membership: small
- (main) Objective: revolutionary state
- (common) Targets: German state, right-wing figures
- Repertoire of actions: kidnapping, robbery, bombing, assassination



Open data - Global Terrorism Database

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Visualisation | Explanatory note | Data table



Other PV groups that will crop up in readings

Brigate Rosse

- Territory of action: Italy
- Organisational structure:
- Membership: small
- (main) Objective: revolutionary state
- (common) Targets: Italian state institutions and NATO
- Repertoire of actions: robberies, kidnapping, low-level violence



Blood & Honour

- Territory of action: international (originally U.K.)
- Organisational structure: network
- Membership: large
- (main) Objective: white ethnostate
- (common) Targets: political and ethnic opponents
- Repertoire of actions: low-level violence, terrorism



Euskadi Ta Askatasuna (ETA, 'Basque Homeland and

- Territory of action: Basque country
- Organisational structure: hierarchical
- Membership: large
- (main) Objective: leftist revolution, independent state
- (common) Targets: state institutions
- Repertoire of actions: kidnapping, terrorism



Fuerzas Armadas Revolucionarias de Colombia

- Territory of action: Colombia
- Organisational structure: hierarchical
- Membership: large
- (main) Objective: leftist revolution
- (common) Targets: state institutions, other paramilitaries
- Repertoire of actions: kidnapping, terrorism, drug trade



Grey Wolves

- Territory of action: international (originally Turkish)
- Organisational structure: hierarchical
- Membership: large
- (main) Objective: promote Turkish nationalism
- (common) Targets: political opponents
- Repertoire of actions: low-level violence



Hammerskins

- Territory of action: international (originally U.S.)
- Organisational structure: network
- Membership: large
- (main) Objective: white ethnostate
- (common) Targets: political and ethnic opponents
- Repertoire of actions: low-level violence, terrorism



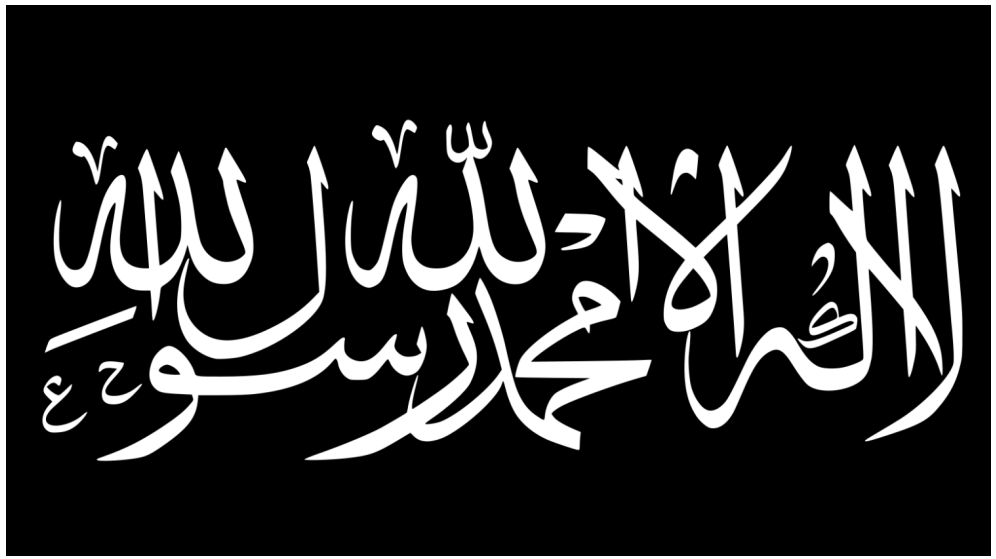
Hezbollah

- Territory of action: Lebanon, but also transnational
- Organisational structure: hierarchical
- Membership: large
- (main) Objective: Islamic state in Lebanon
- (common) Targets: Western forces, the power-sharing in Lebanon
- Repertoire of actions: terrorism



Hizb ut-Tahrir

- Territory of action: international
- Organisational structure: network
- Membership: large
- (main) Objective: united Islamic caliphate
- (common) Targets: political and ethnic opponents
- Repertoire of actions: low-level violence, incitement to violence, terrorism



Irish Republican Army

- Territory of action: British Isles
- Organisational structure: hierarchical
- Membership: large
- (main) Objective: united, independent Ireland
- (common) Targets: British military and institutions
- Repertoire of actions: terrorism



Kommunistische Partei Deutschlands (KPD)

Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam

- Territory of action: Sri Lanka, but also transnational
- Organisational structure: hierarchical
- Membership: large
- (main) Objective: independent Tamil state
- (common) Targets: Sinhalese dominated Sri Lankan state
- Repertoire of actions: assassination, guerrilla activity



Sozialistische Reichspartei (SRP)

- Territory of action: Germany
- Organisational structure: hierarchical
- Membership: large
- (main) Objective: revive national socialist movement
- (common) Targets: political opponents
- Repertoire of actions: low-level violence, support for state violence



Assigning groups for in-depth study

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To get assigned a group to study in depth, scan the QR code or click this LINK

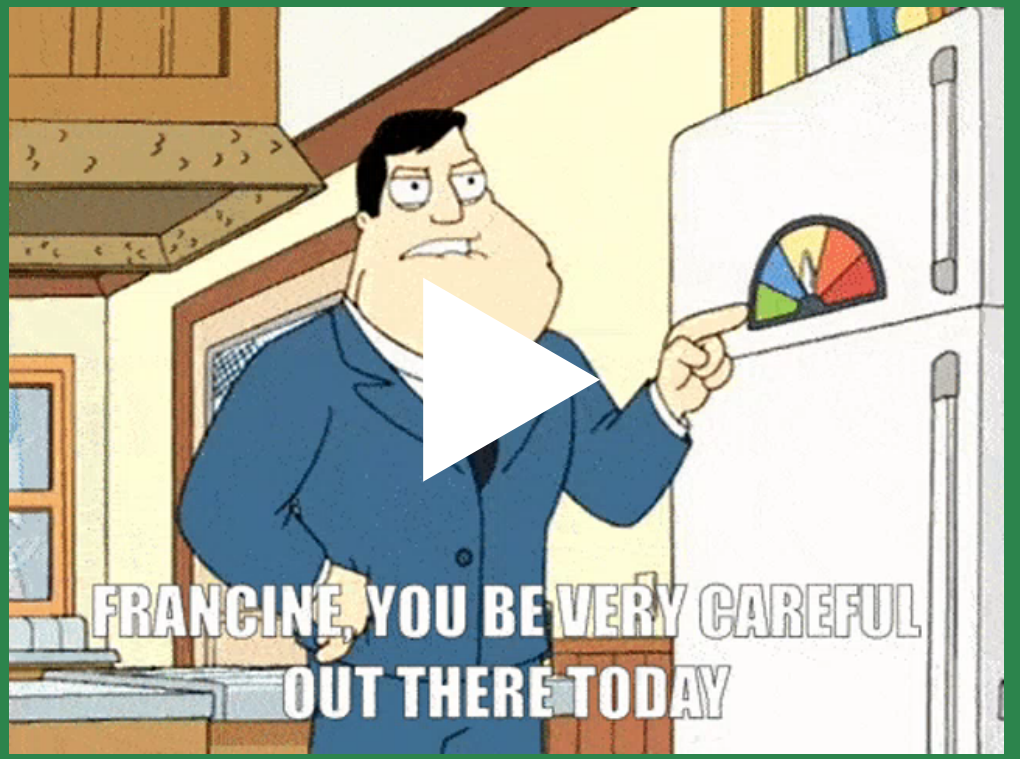
You will be randomly assigned one of these groups:

- Antifa
- RAF - Rote Armee Fraktion
- IS - Islamic State
- alQaeda
- NPD/Heimat
- NSU - Nationalsozialistischer Untergrund
- PKK - Partiya Karkerên Kurdistanê

Testing: determinants of right-wing terrorism in the U.S.

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- Piazza (2017)
  - theorising and testing causes



Piazza (2017) - testing causes

- Three groups of motivations (p. 54)
  - economic hardships and grievances (mechanism: drive resentment and support for terrorism)
  - greater inclusion and empowerment of women and racial minorities (mechanism: perceived threat to privilege)
  - resentment toward the U.S. political system and government (mechanism: necessitates 'resistance against tyranny')

Lays out differing theoretical/empirical contentions/findings about these motivations—and sets out to resolve them (theory-based and empirics-based puzzles) (Day and Koivu 2019)

Piazza (2017) - research design

> the study uses a cross-sectional panel time series design to examine the predictive quality of a series of state and national-level economic, social and political indicators on counts of domestic terrorist attacks launched by right-wing terrorist movements and individuals in the 50 US states for the period 1970–2011.

Let's break this down:

Piazza (2017) - research design

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the study uses a cross-sectional panel time series design to examine the predictive quality of a series of state and national-level economic, social and political indicators on counts of domestic terrorist attacks launched by right-wing terrorist movements and individuals in the 50 US states for the period 1970–2011

- ‘cross-sectional panel time series’ = different clusters of [redacted] analysis over time
  - ‘in the 50 US states for the period 1970–2011’ = state-year is the unit of analysis (see Note 14)
- ‘predictive quality’ = research objective, *predict* (rather than ‘describe’ or ‘explain’), here meaning *inferential statistics*
- ‘series of state and national-level economic, social and political indicators’ = the (groups of) *independent variables* (IVs), corresponding to the 3 groups of motivations
- ‘counts of domestic terrorist attacks launched by right-wing terrorist movements and individuals’ = *dependent variable* (DV)

Piazza (2017) - research design

Variable group	Indicators
Economic grievance	Per cent in poverty
	Per cent employed in manufacturing
	Number of individual farms in state
Societal changes	Rate of abortion
	Per cent of labour force that is female
	Change in non-white state population
'Big government'	measure of Democrat party dominance
	U.S. President a Democrat in given year
	Average income tax rate

Reading a regression table

Remember: regression is a tool for understanding a phenomenon as a linear function (generally) → (y = mx + b)

Piazza (2017) - abridged regression table

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	[1]	[2]	[3]	[4]	[5]	[6]
Percentage Below Poverty Line		0.054			0.026	0.012
		(0.034)			(0.034)	(0.032)
Manufacturing Employment		3.751			22.804	30.732
		(6.751)			(18.584)	(21.832)
Change, No. of Individual Farms		2.532			–1.427	–0.226
		(1.953)			(2.748)	(2.946)
Abortion Rate			0.029**		0.026*	0.022†
			(0.010)		(0.012)	(0.013)
Female Participation in Labor Force			0.102**		0.183†	0.209†
			(0.033)		(0.100)	(0.125)
Growth of Non-white Pop (%)			0.026		0.016	0.015
			(0.016)		(0.020)	(0.016)
Democrat Control of State Government				0.055	–0.010	–0.043
				(0.076)	(0.085)	(0.082)
US President Democrat				0.673**	0.837**	1.164**
				(0.247)	(0.284)	(0.404)
Federal Income Tax Rate				0.043	–0.275	–0.295
				(0.138)	(0.232)	(0.313)

Piazza (2017) - findings (interpetting reg. table)

Piazza (2017) - conclusions

1. economic factors are not reliable predictors of terrorist activity
2. social factors help drive right-wing terrorism. (‘ills afflicting “traditional” American society’)
3. partisan control over government matters at the national level, but not the state level, in determining right-wing terrorism

Any feedback for this class?

Anonymous feedback here:
https://forms.gle/NfF1pCfYMbkAT3WP6

Alternatively, please send me an email: m.zeller@lmu.de

Questions about groups next meeting: (1) Was radicalisation of members motivated more by identity than by ideology? (2) Could individuals realistically have become radicalised without joining a social group connected to the organisation? (3) Was radicalisation into the group mostly *sudden* or *gradual*? (4) How did the group's narratives portray its members/community: victims, defenders, revolutionaries, religious warriors, other? (5) Did major political events accelerate radicalisation?

References

Crenshaw, Martha. 1981. “The Causes of Terrorism.” *Comparative Politics* 13 (4): 379–99.

Day, Christopher, and Kendra L. Koivu. 2019. “Finding the Question: A Puzzle-Based Approach to the Logic of Discovery.” *Journal of Political Science Education* 15 (3): 377–86. https://doi.org/10.1080/15512169.2018.1493594.

Piazza, James A. 2017. “The Determinants of Domestic Right-Wing Terrorism in the USA: Economic Grievance, Societal Change and Political Resentment.” *Conflict Management and Peace Science* 34 (1): 52–80. https://doi.org/10.1177/0738894215570429.